

Singularities in Different Characterstics

Karl Schwede (University of Utah)

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1 Lecture 1

Singularities and Frobenius

Let $(R, \mathfrak{m})$ be a Noetherian local domain. We want to study the singularities of R .

Consider $R \hookrightarrow R'$ or $X \rightarrow \operatorname{Spec} R$. Another variant: Let A be a regular local ring such that $A \twoheadrightarrow R = A/I$. We want to understand I in terms of $A \rightarrow A'$.

Assume the characteristic is $p > 0$. Consider the Frobenius endomorphism:

$$\begin{aligned} F : R &\rightarrow R \\ r &\mapsto r^p \end{aligned}$$

One solution to the problem that the source and target of F are the same is to consider the roots. Let

$$R^{1/p} = \{x \in \overline{K(R)} \mid x^p \in R\},$$

which is the set of p -th roots of elements of R . We have the following diagram connecting the Frobenius map on R with the p -th power map on $R^{1/p}$:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} R & \xrightarrow{F} & R \\ \simeq \downarrow & & \downarrow = \\ R^{1/p} & \xrightarrow{(\cdot)^p} & R \end{array}$$

Theorem 1.1 (Kunz). *Let $(R, \mathfrak{m})$ be a Noetherian local ring of characteristic $p > 0$. Then R is regular if and only if $R^{1/p}$ is a flat R -module. (Note that as rings, $R \simeq R^{1/p}$).*

Example 1.2. Let $R = k[x_1, \dots, x_n]_{\mathfrak{m}}$. Then $R^{1/p} = k^{1/p}[x_1^{1/p}, \dots, x_n^{1/p}]$. In this case, $R^{1/p}$ is free over R , and it has a basis:

$$1, x_1^{1/p}, \dots, x_n^{1/p}, x_1^{1/p} x_2^{1/p}, \dots, (x_1 \dots x_n)^{\frac{p-1}{p}}$$

More precisely, the basis is given by:

$$\{x_1^{a_1/p} \dots x_n^{a_n/p} \mid 0 \leq a_i \leq p-1\}$$

If $[k^{1/p} : k] = \infty$, then $R^{1/p}$ is flat but not free.

Proofs of Kunz's Theorem (Sketches)

Proof of Kunz's Theorem #1: We can reduce to the case where R is complete. Then $R \cong k[[x_1, \dots, x_n]]$ (or some variant of R does this via the Cohen Structure Theorem).

Proof of Kunz's Theorem #2: ($\Rightarrow$) Assume $R^{1/p}$ is a finite R -module (i.e., R is F -finite). By the Auslander-Buchsbaum formula (A-B),

$$\text{pdim}_R(R^{1/p}) + \text{depth}_R(R^{1/p}) = \text{depth}(R) = \dim(R) \quad (*)$$

(Recall that regular implies Cohen-Macaulay (CM), so depth equals dimension).

Say $(x_1, \dots, x_d) = \mathfrak{m} \subseteq R$, where $d = \dim R$. Since $x_1, \dots, x_d$ is a regular sequence on R , it follows that $x_1^p, \dots, x_d^p$ is a regular sequence on R . Under the isomorphism $R \xrightarrow{\cong} R^{1/p}$, the elements x_i form a regular sequence on $R^{1/p}$. This implies that $\text{depth}_R(R^{1/p}) = \dim(R)$. By equation (*), we get $\text{pdim}_R(R^{1/p}) = 0$. Thus, $R^{1/p}$ is projective, which implies it is flat.

Proof of Kunz's Theorem #3: Consider $R \rightarrow R^{1/p}$ as a local map of Noetherian rings such that for the fibers:

- (1) R is regular.
- (2) $\dim(R^{1/p}) = \dim R + \dim(R^{1/p}/\mathfrak{m}R^{1/p})$.
- (3) $R^{1/p}$ is CM.

$\implies R^{1/p}$ is flat over R .

Remark 1.3 (Explanatory Note). The condition $\text{pdim}(R^{1/p}) = 0$ implies the module is projective. Over a local ring, any finitely generated projective module is free, and free modules are flat.

F -split and Strongly F -regular Rings

Assume $R^{1/p}$ is a free R -module with some basis. If there exists a projection onto a factor, ρ , which is surjective, then $\rho(c^{1/p}) = 1$ for some c . Consider the mappings:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} R & \xrightarrow{\cdot c^{1/p}} & R^{1/p} \xrightarrow{\rho} R \\ 1 & \longmapsto & c^{1/p} \longmapsto 1 \end{array}$$

Hence, $R \rightarrow R^{1/p}$ splits as a map of R -modules.

Definition 1.4. R is **F -split** if the natural inclusion $R \rightarrow R^{1/p}$ splits as a map of R -modules.

Now, assume R is regular and F -finite. Suppose $c \in \mathfrak{m}$, $c \neq 0$. Then $c \notin \mathfrak{m}^\ell$ for $\ell \gg 0$. So $c \notin (x_1^\ell, \dots, x_d^\ell)$ (where $(x_1, \dots, x_d) = \mathfrak{m}$). $\implies c \notin (x_1^{p^e}, \dots, x_d^{p^e})$ for $e \gg 0$.

Claim 1.5. $c^{1/p^e} \in R^{1/p^e}/\mathfrak{m}R^{1/p^e}$ is non-zero.

Notice the correspondence $\mathfrak{m}R^{1/p^e} \xrightarrow{\sim} (x_1^{p^e}, \dots, x_d^{p^e}) \subseteq R$. So c^{1/p^e} is part of a basis for $R^{1/p^e}/\mathfrak{m}R^{1/p^e}$ over $R/\mathfrak{m}$. By Nakayama's Lemma (NAK) (using the F -finite assumption), c^{1/p^e} is a part of a basis for R^{1/p^e} over R . $\implies \exists \rho : R^{1/p^e} \rightarrow R$ projecting onto c^{1/p^e} (i.e., mapping it to 1).

Definition 1.6. A ring R (which is F -finite) is **strongly F -regular (SFR)**, if $\forall c \neq 0$, the map $R \xrightarrow{\cdot c^{1/p^e}} R^{1/p^e}$ splits (as a map of R -modules) for some $e > 0$.

Lemma 1.7. If R is F -finite and regular, then R is strongly F -regular (SFR).

Remark 1.8. If you mod out a regular ring by an ideal $I \subseteq \mathfrak{m}^2$, the resulting quotient is never regular.

Example 1.9. 1. $\mathbb{F}_p[x, y, z]_{\mathfrak{m}}/(x^2 - yz)$ is NOT regular, but it is strongly F -regular, hence F -split.

Remark 1.10 (Explanatory Note). This is an A_1 singularity. Note the standard isomorphism with the Veronese subring:

$$\frac{k[x, y, z]}{(x^2 - yz)} \simeq k[ab, a^2, b^2] \subseteq k[a, b]$$

2. $\frac{k[x, y, z]}{(x^3 + y^3 + z^3)}$ for $p \neq 3$ is NEVER strongly F -regular.

(i) It is F -split if $p \equiv 1 \pmod{3}$.

(ii) It is not F -split if $p \equiv 2 \pmod{3}$.

3. $\mathbb{F}_p[x, y, z]_{\mathfrak{m}}/(x^4 + y^4 + z^4)$ is NEVER F -split (even for $p \neq 2$).

How do you check these properties?

- **To show F -splitting:** Exhibit a splitting. If $R \hookrightarrow S$ splits and S is F -split, then R is F -split.

2 Lecture-2

Throughout this lecture, let R be a domain of finite type over a field k of characteristic 0. Frequently R is assumed to be local, say $(R, \mathfrak{m})$. We write

$$X = \operatorname{Spec} R.$$

What Is Resolution of Singularities?

Definition 2.1 (Resolution of singularities). A *resolution of singularities* of $X = \operatorname{Spec} R$ is a proper, usually projective, birational morphism

$$\pi : Y \longrightarrow \operatorname{Spec} R$$

such that Y is non-singular.

In the affine setting, a typical projective birational morphism is obtained as a blowup. Namely, if $I \subseteq R$ is an ideal, then the blowup of $\operatorname{Spec} R$ along I is

$$Y = \operatorname{Proj} S, \quad S = R \oplus It \oplus I^2 t^2 \oplus \cdots.$$

Here $S = \bigoplus_{n \geq 0} I^n t^n$ is the Rees algebra of I . The adjective *birational* means that π is an isomorphism over a dense open subset $U \subseteq \operatorname{Spec} R$. Equivalently, Y and $\operatorname{Spec} R$ have the same function field:

$$k(Y) = \operatorname{Frac}(R).$$

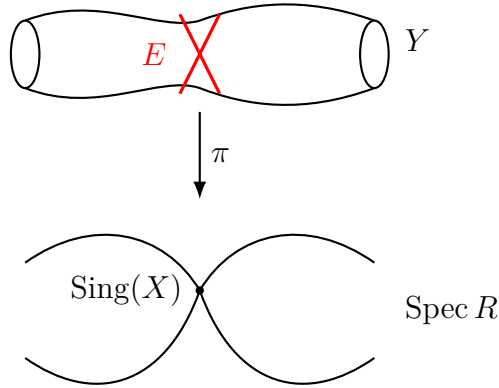


Figure 1: A proper birational morphism resolving the singularity of $\operatorname{Spec} R$. The locus $E \subseteq Y$ is the exceptional set.

Definition 2.2 (Exceptional set). Let $\pi : Y \rightarrow X$ be a resolution of singularities. The *exceptional set* is the closed subset

$$E = \operatorname{Exc}(\pi) \subseteq Y$$

where π is not an isomorphism.

For resolutions in characteristic 0, one may arrange several additional properties.

Proposition 2.3 (Standard refinements of resolution). *Let R be as above and let $X = \operatorname{Spec} R$. After replacing a resolution by a sufficiently refined one, we may assume the following.*

(1) *The morphism*

$$\pi : Y \rightarrow X$$

is an isomorphism over the non-singular locus of X , that is, over $X \setminus \text{Sing}(X)$.

(2) *The exceptional set*

$$E = \text{Exc}(\pi)$$

is a divisor with simple normal crossings. In other words, every irreducible component of E is non-singular, and locally on Y , the divisor E is defined by a partial product of a regular system of parameters.

(3) *More generally, for any ideal $J \subseteq R$, we may arrange that*

$$V(J\mathcal{O}_Y) \cup E$$

has simple normal crossings.

Definition 2.4 (Simple normal crossings). Let Y be a non-singular variety. A divisor $D \subseteq Y$ has *simple normal crossings*, abbreviated SNC, if for every point $y \in Y$, there is a regular system of parameters

$$x_1, \dots, x_d$$

in the regular local ring $\mathcal{O}_{Y,y}$ such that D is locally defined by an equation of the form

$$x_1 x_2 \cdots x_r = 0$$

for some $0 \leq r \leq d$.

Thus, locally at a point $y \in Y$, one can write

$$\mathcal{O}_{Y,y} \cong (R', \mathfrak{m}')$$

where

$$\mathfrak{m}' = (x_1, \dots, x_d),$$

and the exceptional divisor has normal-crossing form, for example

$$E = V(x_1 x_2 \cdots x_r).$$

Remark 2.5. The condition that E be simple normal crossings is crucial because it reduces many local computations on the resolution to computations with monomials in a regular local ring. This is why resolution of singularities is often paired with log-resolution statements: after further blowups, the exceptional divisor and the total transform of a chosen closed subscheme can be made simultaneously monomial in suitable local coordinates.

Example: Blowing Up a Fermat Surface Singularity

Example 2.6. Let

$$R = \frac{k[x, y, z]}{(x^4 + y^4 + z^4)}$$

and let

$$\mathfrak{m} = (x, y, z) \subseteq R.$$

We blow up $X = \operatorname{Spec} R$ at the maximal ideal $\mathfrak{m}$. The blowup is

$$Y = \operatorname{Proj} (R \oplus \mathfrak{m}t \oplus \mathfrak{m}^2t^2 \oplus \cdots).$$

We analyze Y on the standard affine charts.

The x -chart

On the chart where x is the chosen generator of the blowup, introduce coordinates

$$u = \frac{y}{x}, \quad v = \frac{z}{x}.$$

The corresponding affine chart of the blowup is described by

$$k[x, u, v] / (x^4 + x^4u^4 + x^4v^4).$$

Equivalently,

$$k[x, u, v] / (x^4(1 + u^4 + v^4)).$$

The strict transform is obtained by removing the exceptional factor x^4 . Hence the strict transform on this chart has coordinate ring

$$k[x, u, v] / (1 + u^4 + v^4),$$

that is,

$$k \left[x, \frac{y}{x}, \frac{z}{x} \right] / \left(1 + \left(\frac{y}{x} \right)^4 + \left(\frac{z}{x} \right)^4 \right).$$

Let

$$F_1 = 1 + u^4 + v^4 = 1 + \left(\frac{y}{x} \right)^4 + \left(\frac{z}{x} \right)^4.$$

The exceptional divisor in this chart is

$$E = V(x).$$

To check non-singularity of this chart, compute

$$\frac{\partial F_1}{\partial u} = 4u^3, \quad \frac{\partial F_1}{\partial v} = 4v^3, \quad \frac{\partial F_1}{\partial x} = 0.$$

Since $\text{char}(k) = 0$, the equations

$$F_1 = \frac{\partial F_1}{\partial u} = \frac{\partial F_1}{\partial v} = 0$$

would force $u = v = 0$, but then $F_1 = 1 \neq 0$. Hence there are no singular points on this chart:

$$V\left(F_1, \frac{\partial F_1}{\partial u}, \frac{\partial F_1}{\partial v}\right) = \emptyset.$$

The y -chart

On the chart where y is the chosen generator, set

$$a = \frac{x}{y}, \quad b = \frac{z}{y}.$$

The strict transform is given by

$$k[a, y, b] / (a^4 + 1 + b^4),$$

that is,

$$k\left[\frac{x}{y}, y, \frac{z}{y}\right] / \left(\left(\frac{x}{y}\right)^4 + 1 + \left(\frac{z}{y}\right)^4\right).$$

The same Jacobian computation shows that this chart is non-singular.

The z -chart

On the chart where z is the chosen generator, set

$$c = \frac{x}{z}, \quad d = \frac{y}{z}.$$

The strict transform is given by

$$k[c, d, z] / (c^4 + d^4 + 1),$$

that is,

$$k\left[\frac{x}{z}, \frac{y}{z}, z\right] / \left(\left(\frac{x}{z}\right)^4 + \left(\frac{y}{z}\right)^4 + 1\right).$$

Again, by symmetry, this chart is non-singular. Therefore, the blowup at $\mathfrak{m}$ resolves the singularity in this example.

Remark 2.7. The displayed chart rings above describe the strict transform. The total transform contains a common exceptional factor, such as x^4 on the x -chart. The strict transform is the geometrically relevant component for the resolution, obtained by dividing out this exceptional factor.

Cohomology and Rational Singularities

The goal is to relate R , its normalization, and related extensions such as $R^{1/p}$ or R^{1/p^e} in positive characteristic, to the geometry of a resolution

$$\pi : Y \rightarrow \operatorname{Spec} R.$$

A first approximation is to take global sections:

$$\Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y).$$

For a proper birational morphism from a normal variety Y , one obtains

$$\Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y) = R^N,$$

where R^N denotes the normalization of R inside its fraction field. However, $\Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y)$ only records degree-zero cohomological information. Instead, one studies the derived global sections

$$R\Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y).$$

This is a complex whose cohomology groups are

$$H^i(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y) \quad (i \geq 0).$$

It can be viewed as a differential graded algebra, and in the setting of rational singularities it is independent, up to quasi-isomorphism, of the chosen resolution of singularities.

Remark 2.8. The derived object $R\Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y)$ is better behaved than ordinary global sections because it remembers all higher cohomology. Rational singularities are precisely those singularities for which this higher cohomological information contributes nothing beyond the original ring R .

Computing Derived Global Sections by a Čech Complex

Let

$$Y = \bigcup_i U_i$$

be an affine open cover. Then $R\Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y)$ is represented by the Čech complex

$$\check{C}^\bullet(\{U_i\}, \mathcal{O}_Y) :$$

$$\prod_i \Gamma(U_i, \mathcal{O}_Y) \longrightarrow \prod_{i < j} \Gamma(U_i \cap U_j, \mathcal{O}_Y) \longrightarrow \prod_{i < j < \ell} \Gamma(U_i \cap U_j \cap U_\ell, \mathcal{O}_Y) \longrightarrow \cdots .$$

Thus there is a quasi-isomorphism

$$R\Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y) \simeq \check{C}^\bullet(\{U_i\}, \mathcal{O}_Y).$$

For the previous blowup example, the first terms of the Čech complex are of the form

$$\left(k \left[x, \frac{y}{x}, \frac{z}{x} \right] / (\cdots) \right) \oplus \left(k \left[\frac{x}{y}, y, \frac{z}{y} \right] / (\cdots) \right) \oplus \left(k \left[\frac{x}{z}, \frac{y}{z}, z \right] / (\cdots) \right) \longrightarrow \prod_{i < j} \Gamma(U_i \cap U_j, \mathcal{O}_Y) \longrightarrow \cdots.$$

For example, one of the pairwise intersections is represented by a ring of the form

$$k \left[x, \frac{y}{x}, \frac{z}{x}, \frac{x}{y} \right] / (\cdots),$$

where the omitted ideal is obtained by imposing the strict-transform equation and the compatibility relations among the displayed coordinates.

Definition 2.9 (Rational singularities). Let R be a domain essentially of finite type over a field of characteristic 0, and let

$$\pi : Y \rightarrow X = \operatorname{Spec} R$$

be a resolution of singularities. We say that R , or X , has *rational singularities* if the natural map

$$R \longrightarrow R\Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y)$$

is a quasi-isomorphism.

Equivalently, R has rational singularities if

$$R \xrightarrow{\sim} \Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y) = R^N$$

and

$$H^i(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y) = 0 \quad \text{for all } i > 0.$$

Example 2.10. One can prove that

$$R = \frac{k[x, y, z]}{(x^4 + y^4 + z^4)}$$

does not have rational singularities by showing that, for the resolution Y obtained above,

$$H^1(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y) \neq 0.$$

Open Complements and Local Cohomology

Let $J \subseteq R$ be an ideal generated by

$$J = (f_1, \dots, f_n).$$

Set

$$U = \operatorname{Spec} R \setminus V(J).$$

The open subset U is covered by the standard affine opens

$$U_i = D(f_i) = \operatorname{Spec} R[f_i^{-1}].$$

The derived global sections $R\Gamma(U, \mathcal{O}_U)$ are computed by the corresponding Čech complex:

$$R \longrightarrow \prod_i R[f_i^{-1}] \longrightarrow \prod_{i < j} R[(f_i f_j)^{-1}] \longrightarrow \cdots.$$

In the context of a resolution Y , one similarly obtains complexes such as

$$0 \longrightarrow R \longrightarrow R\Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y)[f_1^{-1}] \longrightarrow \cdots,$$

which represent Čech-type constructions associated to local cohomology. In particular, the local cohomology complex $R\Gamma_J(R)$ is modeled by the cone of

$$R \longrightarrow R\Gamma(U, \mathcal{O}_U),$$

up to the standard cohomological shift conventions.

Remark 2.11. The relationship between Čech complexes and local cohomology is as follows. If $J = (f_1, \dots, f_n)$, then the ordinary Čech complex on $f_1, \dots, f_n$ computes $R\Gamma_J(R)$. Equivalently, the complement $\operatorname{Spec} R \setminus V(J)$ is covered by the opens $D(f_i)$, and local cohomology measures the difference between global sections on $\operatorname{Spec} R$ and derived global sections on this open complement.

Why Are Rational Singularities Good?

Normality

Proposition 2.12. *Rational singularities are normal.*

Proof. If R has rational singularities, then by definition the map

$$R \longrightarrow R\Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y)$$

is a quasi-isomorphism. Taking zeroth cohomology gives an isomorphism

$$R \xrightarrow{\sim} H^0(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y) = \Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y).$$

For a resolution $Y \rightarrow \operatorname{Spec} R$, the ring of global sections is the normalization:

$$\Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y) \cong R^N.$$

Therefore

$$R \cong R^N,$$

so R is normal. □

Cohen–Macaulayness

Proposition 2.13. *Rational singularities are Cohen–Macaulay.*

Proof. Let $(R, \mathfrak{m})$ be local of dimension d , and suppose R has rational singularities. Then

$$R \simeq R\Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y)$$

in the derived category. Hence local cohomology gives

$$H_{\mathfrak{m}}^i(R) \cong H_{\mathfrak{m}}^i(R\Gamma(Y, \mathcal{O}_Y)).$$

Using local duality together with the vanishing theorems available for resolutions in characteristic 0, one obtains

$$H_{\mathfrak{m}}^i(R) = 0 \quad \text{for all } i < \dim R.$$

Therefore

$$\text{depth } R = \dim R,$$

so R is Cohen–Macaulay. □

Remark 2.14. The proof that rational singularities are Cohen–Macaulay is not merely a formal consequence of the definition. It uses deep vanishing results, such as Grauert–Riemenschneider vanishing, together with local duality. The guiding principle is that the higher direct images of $\mathcal{O}_Y$ vanish for rational singularities, and the dualizing sheaf on the smooth resolution has strong vanishing properties.

Grauert–Riemenschneider Vanishing

Theorem 2.15 (Grauert–Riemenschneider vanishing). *Let*

$$\pi : Y \rightarrow \text{Spec } R$$

be a resolution of singularities, and let ω_Y be the canonical sheaf of the non-singular variety Y . Then

$$R\Gamma(Y, \omega_Y)$$

is a Cohen–Macaulay complex. Consequently,

$$H^i(Y, \omega_Y) = 0$$

in the relevant cohomological range below the dimension of R .

More precisely, the Cohen–Macaulayness of the complex means that its local cohomology is concentrated in the expected top degree. In the local case, this is the form compatible with local duality and the Cohen–Macaulayness of rings with rational singularities.

Splitting Characterization of Rational Singularities

Theorem 2.16 (Kovács–Bhatt splitting criterion). *Let*

$$X = \operatorname{Spec} R$$

be a variety, or more generally a scheme in the appropriate setting. Then X has rational singularities if and only if for all projective surjective morphisms

$$\pi : Y \rightarrow X,$$

the natural map

$$\mathcal{O}_X \longrightarrow R\pi_* \mathcal{O}_Y$$

splits in the derived category.

The lecture diagram can be rendered schematically as follows:

$$\begin{array}{ccccc} & & Y & \xleftarrow{\text{finite}} & Z \\ & \searrow \text{projective} & \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ \text{RoS} & & \operatorname{Spec} R & \xleftarrow{\quad} & Z' \end{array}$$

Remark 2.17 (Added Context). The splitting condition says that $\mathcal{O}_X$ is a direct summand of $R\pi_* \mathcal{O}_Y$ in the derived category. This is stronger than merely asking for a splitting on ordinary global sections. The derived splitting controls all higher cohomological obstructions at once.

Reduction to Positive Characteristic

Theorem 2.18 (Smith–Hara–Mehta–Srinivas). *Let $R_{\mathbb{Z}}$ be a ring of finite type over $\mathbb{Z}$, and set*

$$R_{\mathbb{Q}} = R_{\mathbb{Z}} \otimes_{\mathbb{Z}} \mathbb{Q}.$$

Assume that $R_{\mathbb{Q}}$ is Gorenstein. Then $R_{\mathbb{Q}}$ has rational singularities if and only if, for all sufficiently large primes p , the characteristic p reduction

$$R_{\mathbb{Z}} \otimes_{\mathbb{Z}} \mathbb{F}_p$$

has strongly F -regular singularities at each localization.

Remark 2.19. This theorem is one of the central bridges between characteristic 0 singularity theory and F -singularity theory. Rational singularities in characteristic 0 correspond, after reduction modulo $p \gg 0$, to strong F -regularity in characteristic p , at least under the stated Gorenstein hypothesis.